Interview prep: Matt Sigelman

- **LinkedIn:** https://www.linkedin.com/in/mattsigelman/
- **Prepared:** 2026-10-15
- **Themes:** 1. AI and jobs over the next 2–5 years · 2. Impact of AI on junior knowledge-worker roles (**primary**) · 3. How recent graduates and junior workers should position themselves

> Guest is already in the guests table (bio + short bio published, no episode title yet → shows as "Coming soon").

Research brief

- **Current role:** President of the Burning Glass Institute, which he founded about five years ago to change how policymakers, employers, educators and workers understand the world of work. He is also a senior advisor to Harvard's Project on the Workforce [2].
- **Career arc:** He worked at McKinsey & Company and Capital One, then spent two decades building the field of real-time labor market data as CEO and later chairman of the company now known as Lightcast [2]. His institute has assembled career histories for about 65 million US workers, roughly 40% of the workforce [2].
- **Other roles:** Chairman of Main Line Classical Academy, which he founded [1][2]. Member of the Council on Foreign Relations and board member of The Graduate! Network [1].
- **Core framework, the "expertise upheaval":** Developed with Harvard's Joseph Fuller and Michael Fenlon. The idea is that gen AI's biggest effect is a change in the *level of expertise* jobs require, more than in how many jobs there are. They estimate gen AI will affect about 50 million jobs and that "traditional learning curves for jobs will be redrawn" [4][2].
- **Key recent research:** *No Country for Young Grads* (July 2025), which he co-authored. It finds that young degree holders face faster-rising unemployment than any other education or age group. It names four reinforcing causes: the expertise upheaval, lean post-pandemic staffing, AI as an accelerant, and a graduate glut [3].
- **Notable positions:**
  - "So far, there is little evidence of big drops in employment," but the skills used inside jobs, and the level of expertise they require, are changing sharply [2].
  - Students will need to "start their career in the middle instead of at the beginning" [2][6].
  - He argues AI should be used to make "people's work worth more," not just cheaper [2].

Opener

Q. You've described the labor market as running on "cosmic coincidence": the great employee who just happened to need a job when that restaurant happened to be hiring. What first made you want to replace coincidence with data?

- *Why ask:* An easy, personal start that sets up the 65-million-career-histories dataset everything else rests on [2].

Theme 1: AI and jobs over the next 2–5 years

His public position is consistently anti-catastrophist on job counts. The history of general-purpose technologies suggests they change "the way we work much more often than whether we work" [2]. He pairs that with a warning that changes in skills and expertise "could be just as disruptive" [2]. His own report leaves open whether today's disruption peaks early or deepens [3].

Q1. You've said so far there's little evidence of big drops in employment, but very meaningful changes inside jobs. Looking out two to five years, do you expect that pattern to hold, or does the job-count story start to change?

- *Follow-up:* What would you need to see in the data to change your mind?
- *Why ask:* This is his headline position, and it's worth testing against a medium-term horizon [2].

Q2. One of your more surprising findings is that the jobs seeing the most automation are the same jobs seeing the most augmentation. What does that mean for an executive deciding which roles to redesign first?

- *Follow-up:* If the freed-up time gets filled with new tasks, who decides what those tasks are, and how should they decide?
- *Why ask:* It directly contradicts the "winners and losers" model most leaders carry around [2].

Q3. Your *No Country for Young Grads* report lays out two futures. In one, AI's replacement of junior roles "might peak in these early years," once the easy substitutions are made. In the other, the erosion of on-the-job learning deepens as AI improves. Which do you think we're on, and what's the signal you're watching?

- *Follow-up:* Does the answer differ by sector, say finance versus professional services versus tech?
- *Why ask:* It puts his own two scenarios to him and asks him to place a bet [3].

Q4. Some critics argue it's premature to blame AI. They say the drop in new-graduate hiring started before generative AI was widely adopted, and a New York Fed survey found firms reporting negligible AI effects on hiring. How do you separate AI from lean staffing and the graduate glut?

- *Follow-up:* Is "AI as accelerant," rather than AI as root cause, the more accurate headline?
- *Why ask:* It's a fair challenge, and his own report frames AI as one of four reinforcing forces, so he can engage it without getting defensive [11][3].

Q5. You've argued we almost always talk about productivity through the denominator, meaning less or cheaper labor, and almost never through the numerator: making people's work worth more. What does a numerator-first AI strategy look like inside a company?

- *Follow-up:* Can you point to an employer that's actually doing it?
- *Why ask:* This is the leadership-strategy hook for the show's audience, and it's his own framing [2].

Q6. You've described skilled technical jobs that rely on hands-on human judgment as a "safe center" while AI moves into professional work, and said we haven't trained people for them because of a lack of investment, not awareness. Over the next five years, where does that leave the traditional white-collar track?

- *Follow-up:* Does that change what leaders should be funding in their own workforce development?
- *Why ask:* It complicates the assumption that knowledge work is the safe path [5].

Theme 2: Impact of AI on junior knowledge-worker roles (primary)

This is where his research is deepest. His learning-curve framework separates "Growth Roles" like marketing specialist, project manager and financial analyst, where employers need fewer juniors and more experienced staff, from "Mastery Roles," where entry-level opportunity may actually grow [3]. Job-postings data show the drop in entry-level demand is concentrated in occupations highly exposed to large language models. Junior hiring in low-exposure roles has grown since 2022 [3].

Q1. Walk us through the learning-curve idea: your bus driver versus data scientist example. Why does the shape of a job's learning curve decide whether AI shrinks or expands entry-level opportunity?

- *Follow-up:* What are some Mastery Roles where you expect AI to open doors for people without prior expertise?
- *Why ask:* It's the core of his framework, and leaders need the intuition before the data [2][3].

Q2. You've said it's "super tempting" for employers to ask why they'd hire at the entry level when an experienced person can unleash the power of AI. Then you ask: "Where do I get experts if the way that people developed expertise historically is by starting at the bottom?" What's your answer for a CEO?

- *Follow-up:* Is anyone pricing in the cost of a missing generation of mid-level talent five to ten years out?
- *Follow-up:* Does this become a competitive advantage for firms that keep hiring juniors?
- *Why ask:* This is the central dilemma of the episode, in his own words [2].

Q3. Your report names the tasks at risk: research, first drafts, basic data analysis and routine communications, the "stepping stones" junior employees used to learn on. It calls the result a "Flipped Pyramid." Which roles is that hitting hardest right now?

- *Follow-up:* Has anything shifted since July 2025 in which occupations are most affected?
- *Why ask:* It turns the framework into a concrete picture of the junior job [3].

Q4. The numbers in *No Country for Young Grads* are stark. Unemployment for 20-to-24-year-olds with a bachelor's degree went from 5.2% in 2018–19 to 6.2% in the two years through June 2025. The

gap with less-educated peers is the narrowest in three decades, and layoff rates for young grads have nearly doubled. Is this a crisis, or the painful middle of a transition?

- *Follow-up:* You've also cited a 9% decline in entry-level hiring compared to expert hires. Is that gap still widening?
- *Follow-up:* You told the *Wall Street Journal* this is "a more tectonic shift in the way employers are hiring." Do you still see it that way a year later?
- *Why ask:* The data anchor for the primary theme, and it lets him update the 2025 figures [3][5] [10].

Q5. You've been a leading voice for skills-based hiring, even calling for a "nutrition label" on credentials. Yet you've also warned that as entry-level work changes, "we will end up relying on degrees more than we do today." How do you reconcile those two?

- *Follow-up:* What should a hiring manager screen for in a junior candidate when the junior tasks are being automated?
- *Why ask:* There's a real tension in his public statements, and it's worth drawing out [8].

Q6. You've cautioned that if AI is used to replace effort rather than augment it, workers won't build the skills they need. What does a well-designed junior role look like in an AI-heavy team, one where people still learn?

- *Follow-up:* Is apprenticeship the right model for knowledge work, or does it need something new?
- *Why ask:* It moves from diagnosis to what leaders can actually redesign [8][7].

Theme 3: How recent graduates and junior workers should position themselves

His advice is specific and on the record:

- Start careers "in the middle" [2][6].
- Get real work experience early; he writes that a single internship halves the risk of underemployment [6].
- Study employer demand and build a skills inventory [5].
- Develop computational thinking and your own voice instead of outsourcing it to AI [5].
- In his words, if he were 22 today, he'd "be looking wider" [1].

Q1. You've said, "If I were 22 today, I'd be looking wider." Wider in what sense: industries, geographies, job types, non-degree paths?

- *Follow-up:* What's a path you think graduates are overlooking right now?
- *Why ask:* It's a memorable, personal line from his own feed, a natural way into practical advice [1].

Q2. You've asked, "How do you learn to do at 22 what you used to not need to know until you were 27?" What's the honest answer for someone graduating this year?

- *Follow-up:* What should colleges be doing differently so students can start in the middle?
- *Why ask:* His sharpest framing of the junior-worker challenge, turned into advice [2][6].

Q3. You've written that a single internship halves the risk of underemployment, and that even the part-time jobs high school students already hold should count as learning. Why is work-based experience so powerful, and what if a student couldn't get an internship?

- *Follow-up:* Should employers worried about the junior pipeline be offering more internships, or different ones?
- *Why ask:* It's a concrete, data-backed lever that both graduates and employers can act on [6][1].

Q4. You've said students often "outsource their voice rather than develop it," and you'd make sure your own kids develop strong computational thinking. How should a young professional use AI without hollowing out the skills that make them valuable?

- *Follow-up:* Does that change which majors or courses you'd point a student toward?
- *Why ask:* It speaks directly to how junior workers use AI day to day [5][8].

Q5. Your research shows the first job matters enormously. Some "launchpad jobs" have carried about two million workers without degrees to six-figure salaries, and the wrong first job can put people on a low-wage path for years. How should a graduate evaluate a first offer?

- *Follow-up:* What does it mean to choose a job for its trajectory rather than its starting salary?
- *Why ask:* It applies his career-history data to a decision every listener's kids or junior staff face [9][2].

Q6. You've advised students to "study what employers want": read job ads, look at LinkedIn, build a skills inventory. How does someone do that well when what employers want is shifting this fast?

- *Follow-up:* Which skills are holding their value best in your data?
- *Why ask:* It turns his labor-market-data approach into a tool listeners can use themselves [5][2].

Closer

Q. If a leader listening today did just one thing in the next twelve months to protect the entry-level pipeline in their organization, what should it be? And where can listeners follow the Burning Glass Institute's work?

- *Why ask:* It ends on action for the show's executive audience and gives the guest a plug.

Sources

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